

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

Mayor's CTU ties drew ethics concern

CEO Martinez wins temporary restraining order against the school board after contentious ouster

By **Nell Salzman and Alice Yin**
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson's hand-picked school board was blocked from modifying Chicago Public Schools CEO Pedro Martinez's duties by a Cook County judge on Tuesday, giving the embattled schools chief a victory as he fights with City Hall over the district's future.

Judge Joel Chupack granted Martinez a temporary restraining order against Chicago Board of Education members after hearing

arguments that they'd obstructed Martinez's performance of his job duties.

The Tuesday hearing — which lasted over an hour and a half — included an assertion by Martinez's lawyer, William J. Quinlan, that board members appointed by Johnson met with the teachers union but not their own team while negotiating the teachers contract Monday.

"They're not shy about the interference. They're brazen. They're

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Chicago Public Schools CEO Pedro Martinez speaks on Tuesday. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

CPS official feared conflict of interest as Johnson refused to resign position during 2023 campaign

By **Nell Salzman, Alice Yin and Gregory Royal Pratt**
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson declined to resign his position with Chicago Public Schools after a high-ranking CPS official raised ethics concerns about a potential conflict of interest, according to a memo obtained by the Tribune.

CPS Chief Talent Officer Ben Felton wrote a memo less than two months after the mayor's May 2023 inauguration documenting conversations Felton had with Johnson's deputy mayor for education, Jen Johnson, about their leaves from the Chicago Teachers

Union. Union members can sometimes take leaves of absence to take other jobs and return later.

In the memo, dated June 28, 2023, Felton wrote that he told Deputy Mayor Johnson, who is not related to Mayor Johnson, that "it was potentially a conflict of interest for Mayor Johnson and Deputy Mayor Johnson to remain on a CTU leave from CPS."

Felton said he was "concerned that it could be a potential conflict of interest for the mayor to be an employee of an organization that he was overseeing (through the appointment of the Board of

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A white Christmas here just a dream

Already slim chance for snow narrowed in updated forecast

By **Adriana Pérez**
Chicago Tribune

Are you dreaming of a white Christmas this year? Keep on dreaming, Chicago.

Meteorologists expect the day to be the opposite of a winter wonderland: dreary, cloudy and damp. The probability of getting more than 1 inch of snowfall has been historically low for the date, at around 35% — and those odds might be stacked higher against a magical day this year.

The city has only experienced one white Christmas in the past six years. It was 2022, and even then it barely qualified with 1 inch of snow. Before then, in 2016 and 2017, Chicagoans woke up to at least 2 inches of snow the mornings of Dec. 25.

"Typically, the Chicago area has a white Christmas about once every three to four years," said Brett Borchardt, senior meteorologist at the National Weather Service office in Chicago. "It does not look like we're gonna have a white Christmas this year, though. I know there are still some spots that have snow out there, especially in the north suburbs — that's all going to go away."

Borchardt said to expect highs near 40 degrees on Wednesday with showers, drizzles and even some fog.

Chances of a white Christmas in the United States have been historically best in Alaska, the Northern Plains and Rockies, the Great Lakes region

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For some Chicago interfaith families, Christmas and Hanukkah are a chance to explore new cultures and appreciate heritage — whether the holidays fall on the same day or not



Building new traditions

By **Caroline Kubzansky**
Chicago Tribune

Peter Kujawinski is pleased with the twist he's given his family's "super-cheesy Christmas family pajama" tradition this year.

"I haven't told anybody this yet," he said. "But I ordered Hanukkah pajamas because you have to take advantage of (Hanukkah) being on the same day."

For Peter, 50, who was raised Roman Catholic, and his wife, Nancy Kujawinski, who was raised in a Reform Jewish family, Hanukkah beginning on Christmas Day brings their two sets of already intertwined traditions into even closer proximity.

The Lincoln Square couple and their three children are one of a growing number of American families who belong to more than one religion. The rise in intermarriage is particularly pronounced among American Jews: A Pew Research survey from several years ago found that about 42% of U.S. Jews were married to people

Dan Gazdic, Briana Lee and Nancy Kujawinski lead carols during a holiday block party on Dec. 14 in Chicago's Lincoln Square neighborhood.

Kujawinski was raised in a Reform Jewish family, and her husband was raised Roman Catholic.

For the family, Hanukkah beginning on Christmas Day this year brings their two sets of already intertwined traditions even closer together.

ADDISON ANNIS/FORTHE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

who are not Jewish — and among Jewish people who had gotten married since 2010, 61% of those marriages were to people of other faiths.

The holidays can present tricky choices for these families, said Samira Mehta, a scholar of interfaith family life at the University of Colorado at Boulder. But, she said, most people in interfaith marriages enter their partnerships with mutual respect for each other's traditions. Ideally, that respect shows in how a family chooses to celebrate holidays in December and throughout the rest of the year.

"I really don't think it matters what any individual interfaith family decides to do," she said. "I think it matters that they make the decision in a way that is respectful."

The Kujawinskis have settled on an all-inclusive approach to their holidays, beginning with the traditional Polish fish dinner and Oplatki, traditional Christmas wafers, on Christmas Eve. They

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Leylani Valencia, 8, a patient in Lurie Children's Single Ventricle Center of Excellence, performs in the Fontan Choir at Northwestern University in Evanston on Dec. 4. **TESS CROWLEY/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

For these kids, 'a powerful connection'

Northwestern-Lurie choir for those born with heart condition improves breathing, confidence

By **Lisa Schencker**
Chicago Tribune

Each child had already undergone at least three open-heart surgeries.

They'd endured countless hours in doctors' offices and hospitals after being born with a serious heart condition.

But this fall the kids tried a new, very different tactic to boost their wellness: They joined a choir. Fourteen children from ages 8 to

16 with a condition called single ventricle circulation, or "Fontan" circulation, met once a week for two months to learn singing and breathing techniques and practice songs for a winter concert at Northwestern University. Researchers at Lurie Children's Hospital and Northwestern's Bienen School of Music created the group to assess the health benefits of singing in a choir for children living with the heart condition.

Children with Fontan circula-

tion are born missing a chamber of the heart that normally pumps blood to the lungs. In the past, such children often didn't live long past birth. Now, doctors can treat it by performing a series of surgeries — the first of which takes place just weeks after birth and the last of which, the Fontan operation, is often performed before kindergarten.

Though the surgeries save the children's lives, the patients still may need heart transplants as adults. As kids, they often face limitations such as shortness of

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